whom donates around 500 kyat (US$0.39) for every funeral sponsored by their network.[7] Many groups provide a customized receipt for each funeral donation, containing language that emphasizes the merit-making nature of the assistance. Between 70,000 and 150,000 kyat (US$54–116) is subsequently raised from the network to cover the various costs associated with funerals, and related rituals, and social events. These include the costs of gatherings usually held on the day prior to the funeral at the house of the deceased, where the family serves food and offers a small bag of gifts to attendees. The bag frequently contains a small bottle of water, some soap or washing powder, and a plastic fan with the name of the deceased printed on one side, and Pali verses for chanting on the other. The family of the deceased again collects donations at this gathering, with those of a more intimate relationship offering more — typically between 3000 (US$2.33) and 10,000 kyat (US$7.76).

Funerals are thus a major moment of sociality, in which large amounts of money change hands through various mechanisms of risk-pooling and redistribution, some of which is returned in-kind to guests. Attendees I interviewed felt obliged to make contributions both to neighbourhood or village funeral teams out of a combination of intimacy with the family, knowledge of the expense of funerals, a sense of reciprocity that they will receive the same support in the future, and also due to social pressure applied by local authorities. Griffiths (2015) observes that these mechanisms of communal risk-sharing are common across Myanmar and continue to play an essential role in complementing government welfare services, especially for the needy.

Comparative research on new democracies and transitions from authoritarian rule highlight that these types of non-state welfare networks play significant roles in framing discursively and ideologically what is seen to be at stake in the political arena, as well as in influencing how people are drawn into the political process. As Steven Levitsky (2001, 2003) notes, such 'informal institutions' tying social life to political process can be essential to analysis of party organizations, political cleavages, and party systems in many new democracies. Similar studies in Southeast Asia (Nishizaki 2004; 2011) and Africa (Ferguson 2015; MacLean 2010) also emphasize the role of everyday social practices and receipt of welfare assistance in framing individuals' notions of citizenship and rights.

It is no surprise then that political parties seek to engage and mobilize the same practices and networks of charitable welfare that helped many